

● BEASTLY FACTS · CARE PACKAGE

TARANTULA · THERAPHOSIDAE

Keep your tarantula the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: why the enclosure is low and wide, substrate depth, the fasting that isn't a problem, the dehydration that is, and molting from start to finish.

21 pages

Beginner friendly

Print or tablet

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CONTENTS

What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

GETTING STARTED

How to Use This Package	3
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SECTION 01 · QUICK PROFILE

Quick Profile & Cost Overview	4
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SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Enclosure Shape & Substrate	5
Humidity, Temperature & Ventilation	6
Handling, or Why You Don't	7
Diet & Feeding by Life Stage	8
Common Mistakes & Enrichment	9

SECTION 03 · HEALTH & COMMON ISSUES

Health Red Flags & the Vet Problem	10
Dehydration, the One That Kills	11
Molting, Start to Finish	12
Falls, Trauma & Other Conditions	13

SECTION 04 · QUICK REFERENCE

Setup Checklist & Environment Targets	14
Emergency & Quick Targets Card	15

SECTION 05 · OWNER TOOLS

Budget & Shopping List	16
First 90 Days Checklist	17
Symptom Quick Reference	18
Routine & Molt Log	19
Enrichment Checklist	20

REFERENCE

Glossary	21
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How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 9 in order. Tarantula setups are refreshingly simple compared to most exotic pets, no complex lighting, no elaborate temperature gradients, but the two details that matter, enclosure shape and substrate depth, matter a great deal and are awkward to change later. Then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 16.

If your tarantula is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Environment Targets on page 14 to audit what you have. If your tarantula has stopped eating, go to page 8 before you worry: in this species a long fast is usually normal. If the abdomen looks shrunk or the legs are curling underneath, go to page 11 instead, because that one is urgent.

Print these first

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Page 14: Setup Checklist & Environment Targets | ☐ Page 19: Routine & Molt Log |
| ☐ Page 15: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 20: Enrichment Checklist |
| ☐ Page 18: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 12: Molting, for the first time it happens |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Tarantula keeping runs on hobby consensus more than on published research, and where the research does exist, it is often quoted selectively. Page 9 gives you the one controlled housing study in full, including the results that do not support the conclusion people usually draw from it. Where sources genuinely disagree, this package says so rather than picking a number and pretending.

THE VET PROBLEM, STATED UP FRONT

Veterinary care for tarantulas is genuinely limited, and many areas have no vet who treats invertebrates at all. That reshapes everything: prevention through correct husbandry does most of the work here, and knowing what is normal versus what is actually wrong matters more than knowing what to do once it has gone wrong.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance. Figures lean toward the commonly kept New World terrestrial species.

Family	Theraphosidae. Over 900 species on every continent except Antarctica
Adult size	2 to 12 in leg span depending on species
Captive lifespan	Females 15 to 20+ years; males typically 4 to 7
Native range	Tropics and subtropics; desert, grassland, rainforest, and canopy by species
Diet type	Carnivore, live insect prey only. No formulated diet exists
Enclosure minimum (adult terrestrial)	About 20 × 10 × 10 in, roughly 3× the leg span, under 12 in tall
Social needs	Solitary and cannibalistic. House singly, at any enclosure size
Handling	Look, don't touch. A fall can be fatal and urticating hairs can injure you
Conservation status	Varies by species; many listed in CITES Appendix II, some Endangered

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$70 to \$300 before the spider. A beginner species runs \$25 to \$100, and a Chilean rose hair or curly hair typically \$20 to \$50. Spiderlings cost less than adults.

Ongoing

\$5 to \$15 a month for feeder insects, or roughly \$60 to \$180 a year. There is no pet insurance for tarantulas and very little routine vet cost to budget for.

THE CHEAPEST LONG COMMITMENT IN THE HOBBY

A female can live 15 to 20 years or more on a food budget of about \$10 a month. Set against most exotic pets that is remarkable value, but it is a genuine two-decade commitment, so buy the species you actually want rather than the one that is in the shop.

Fun facts worth knowing

- Females keep molting throughout their adult lives, unlike most invertebrates, which stop at maturity. Males stop molting once mature, which is a large part of why they live so much shorter.
- Digestion happens outside the body. A tarantula injects enzymes through its fangs to liquefy the prey's insides, then a muscular sucking stomach pumps the meal in, leaving the empty exoskeleton behind as a small pellet.
- Hemolymph, the tarantula equivalent of blood, is not confined to vessels. It flows freely through the body cavity and bathes the organs directly, which is why an abdominal rupture turns fatal so quickly.
- Urticating hairs are strictly a New World trait. Old World species never developed them and lean much harder on bites, which is why they are considered a step up in risk.

Enclosure shape & substrate

Most commonly kept pet tarantulas are terrestrial, and the enclosure should be horizontal, wider than it is tall, specifically to limit fall risk. Everything about terrestrial tarantula enclosure design comes back to not letting the spider fall. A reasonable adult minimum is around 20 by 10 by 10 inches, roughly a 10-gallon tank, sized to about three times the leg span, with overall height kept under about 12 inches.



About 20 × 10 × 10 in for an adult terrestrial, roughly 3× the leg span. No sand.
House singly. Most species are solitary and cannibalistic, at any enclosure size.

NEVER USE A MESH LID

A tarantula's feet can catch in mesh and tear, which is a real and avoidable injury. Acrylic with drilled ventilation holes gives you a secure lid without the hazard.

Substrate

At least 3 inches, filling roughly half to two-thirds of the enclosure. Coconut fiber, peat, or organic pesticide-free soil all hold moisture appropriately and hold a burrow shape without collapsing. Never sand. Depth is species-dependent: an obligate burrower needs far more than a terrestrial species that mostly sits under a piece of bark, and an arboreal species needs height and a vertical retreat instead. Get the species right before you buy the enclosure.

Humidity, temperature & ventilation

CONDITION	TARGET
Temperature	Room temperature, roughly 70 to 80°F
Supplemental heat	Not needed in most homes
Heat mat, if the room runs cold	Mounted on the side, never the bottom, on a thermostat
Humidity, dry-adapted species	Commonly cited as 40 to 60%
Humidity, clinical sources	Sometimes cited as 65 to 75%
Lighting	None required. Avoid bright light and direct sun
Water dish	Shallow, kept full, changed daily, for every species

THE HUMIDITY NUMBERS GENUINELY DISAGREE, AND IT MATTERS LESS THAN IT LOOKS

Some care guides recommend a moderate 40 to 60% for commonly kept dry-adapted species. Others, often written from a clinical or exotic-vet perspective, suggest 65 to 75%. Rather than chasing either number with a spray bottle, the consistent approach is a reliable water dish plus lightly moistened substrate. Overflowing the dish to dampen one corner is how most keepers manage humidity, and it is more stable than misting.

Ventilation, and why heavy misting backfires

Heavy misting raises mold risk without a clear benefit, and mold and mites are both husbandry problems rather than illnesses: they follow poor ventilation and enclosure sanitation, and they resolve when those are corrected. Cross-ventilation through drilled holes on more than one face keeps air moving without drying the substrate out. If you can smell the enclosure, or see fuzz on leftover prey, ventilation is the thing to fix first.

Why a side-mounted heat mat

A mat under the enclosure heats the substrate the tarantula burrows into to escape heat, which is exactly backwards. Mounted on one side wall, it creates a gradient the spider can move away from. Run it through a thermostat regardless, and in most homes skip it entirely: this is a room-temperature animal.

WHAT TO ACTUALLY WATCH

Judge the setup on substrate condition, ventilation, and whether the water dish is full, not on how the spider looks or how much it moves. A still tarantula tells you nothing about your husbandry, which is exactly why the physical checks carry the weight here.

Handling, or why you don't

If you are hoping for a pet you can hold, a tarantula is the wrong choice, and that is worth knowing before you buy one rather than after. The risk runs in both directions.

The risk to the spider

A fall from your hand, your shoulder, or a couch cushion can rupture a tarantula's abdomen, and that is often fatal. Even a short fall, the kind that would not concern you for a moment with any other pet, can be catastrophic here. There is no margin for error, and it is the reason enclosures for this species are built low and wide in the first place.

The risk to you

New World species defend themselves by flicking urticating hairs, tiny barbed hairs that cause skin, respiratory, and eye irritation on contact. Bites are uncommon and rarely medically serious, roughly comparable to a hornet sting, but the real problem with a bite is what happens next: a reflexive jerk or drop, which brings you straight back to the fall risk and often kills the spider that was only defending itself.

URTICATING HAIRS DESERVE REAL RESPECT

If they get into your eye the injury can be serious, penetrating deep enough to cause corneal damage and, in serious cases, complications requiring an ophthalmologist. This is the more common real-world injury from tarantula keeping, not bites. Wash your hands after any enclosure work and keep them away from your face until you have.

What interacting actually looks like

- ☐ Long tongs for cup-guided moves or rearranging decor
- ☐ Enclosure maintenance done without touching the spider directly
- ☐ A catch cup and a piece of card for the rare move that has to happen
- ☐ Observation as the relationship, which is genuinely rewarding on its own terms

Reading defensive behavior

Rearing up on the hind legs, flicking hairs toward a perceived threat, and displaying the fangs are all defensive signals. None of them mean the spider is aggressive in the way that word implies with a mammal. They are responses from an animal that would much rather be left alone, and the correct answer to all of them is to back off and close the lid.

NEVER DURING A MOLT

A molting tarantula has a fragile new exoskeleton for weeks afterward. Do not handle, disturb, or feed during this period. This is one of the few absolute rules in tarantula keeping, and page 12 covers what a normal molt looks like from start to finish.

Diet & feeding by life stage

This is the one pet on the site where skipping meals is genuinely normal rather than a red flag. Prey should never be larger than the tarantula's own abdomen, and any uneaten prey comes out within 24 hours.

LIFE STAGE	FREQUENCY	NOTES
Sling (under about 2 in)	Every 2 to 3 days	Pinhead crickets, fruit flies, or prey no larger than its own abdomen
Juvenile (about 2 to 4 in)	Every 4 to 14 days	Sources disagree most here. Adjust on abdomen size and appetite, not a calendar
Subadult and adult	Every 1 to 2 weeks	Strongly species-dependent. A rose hair may need 4 or 5 crickets a month
Mature adult male	Often little or nothing	Many eat markedly less or stop after the final molt. A natural end-of-life pattern

What they eat

Live insect prey, with no formulated diet to fall back on. Crickets are the default. Dubia or discoid roaches are a good alternative, more nutrient-dense and slower to digest. Mealworms and superworms are supplemental, and crushing the head first on larger roaches and superworms stops them biting. Waxworms occasionally, since they are fatty. The largest species can take a pinky mouse but do not need one.

Gut-load, do not dust

Gut-load feeders for a day or two before offering so the nutrition actually transfers. Skip calcium and vitamin dusting entirely: that is a reptile practice, and hobby consensus is against it here, with anecdotal reports linking it to bad molts. One source notes there is no strong evidence of harm, so treat it as a precaution rather than a proven fact, but the guidance across care sites is consistent.

NEVER FEED

Wild-caught insects of any kind, because the pesticide and parasite risk is not worth it. Fireflies specifically are a hard no across tarantula-keeping resources; the strongest documented toxicity data is for reptiles rather than tarantulas directly, but the precaution is consistent enough to take seriously. Skip processed human food entirely. And never leave live prey in with a spider approaching a molt: crickets will chew on a soft tarantula, and that is a real killer.

Why they stop eating

Premolt fasting is by far the most common reason: a darkening, plumping abdomen and reduced activity precede a molt, and it can last weeks in a sling or several months in an adult. **Post-molt recovery** accounts for another stretch, 3 to 7 days for slings and juveniles, 7 to 14 for adults. Then **mature male mating drive**, **a recent rehoming or an off husbandry detail**, **species-specific fasting tendency** (rose hairs are notorious), and simple **prey pickiness**. Only the last item on the list, appetite loss paired with not drinking, visible injury, uncoordinated legs, or a curled posture, points to a real problem.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- A tall enclosure, which turns an ordinary climb into a fatal fall.
- A mesh lid, which catches feet and tears them.
- A shallow layer of substrate in an enclosure designed to be looked into, which is the most common genuine welfare failure in the hobby.
- Handling, which is where most falls happen.
- Leaving uneaten live prey in the enclosure, especially near a molt.
- Misting heavily instead of running a full water dish, which grows mold without helping.
- Panicking at a fast and force-feeding, when the spider is simply in premolt.
- Disturbing or feeding a tarantula that is molting or has just molted.

THE ONE CONTROLLED HOUSING STUDY, TOLD STRAIGHT

Stalter and colleagues, in *PLoS ONE* in 2024, compared Standard against Complex housing for Brazilian black tarantulas, Complex being roughly six times larger with six times as many structural elements. Activity did not change, and inactivity accounted for nearly all observed behavior in both. Space use did change: home ranges were 77% larger and core areas 113% larger. Boldness changed: 150% greater odds of being active in a novel environment afterward. And offered both at once, the spiders showed no clear preference. The authors' own conclusion is cautious, and a guide quoting only the flattering results is not telling you the truth.

Enrichment, by priority

1. Substrate depth and enclosure type

Matched to the species. Nothing in that study displaces this, and it is where the real welfare failures happen.

3. A retreat it can modify

Cork bark laid down as a starter burrow, or mounted vertically for an arboreal species. Let the spider rearrange substrate and web up the entrance. That is the closest thing to construction this animal does.

5. Floor area beyond the minimum

The 77% space-use result is real, so go larger where you sensibly can. Two limits: never add fall height, and a very large enclosure makes a small spider hard to find and hard to feed.

2. Water, always

A shallow dish kept full, for every species including arid ones. Chronic dehydration kills more captive tarantulas than anything else on this page, and it is entirely preventable.

4. Correct humidity and ventilation

Managed through the dish and lightly damp substrate rather than through misting, which trades a humidity problem for a mold problem.

6. Low structure to move through

Cork flats, leaf litter, a low branch, sphagnum moss, anchored so nothing can shift onto the animal. Low, always, for a terrestrial species.

Health red flags

What is actually wrong, and what only looks like it.

ACT NOW IF YOU SEE
A shrunken, wrinkled, raisin-like abdomen · legs curling tightly underneath the body, the "death curl" · hemolymph leaking from any injury · an inability to lift the body off the ground · uncoordinated or jerky leg movement · a molt that has stalled part way · white material around the mouthparts

DO NOT ACT ON ANY OF THESE
Sitting motionless for days. Refusing food for weeks. Sealing itself into its burrow. Turning dull and dark before a molt. Lying on its back with the legs in the air, which is a tarantula molting, not a tarantula dying. All of these are normal, and reacting to them is how keepers cause the problems they were trying to prevent.

Why prevention carries the weight here

Veterinary care for invertebrates is genuinely rare, and many areas have no one who treats them. There is also no pet insurance for tarantulas and no routine wellness exam to build a baseline. What you have instead is the enclosure itself, which is why almost every entry in this section resolves back to substrate, ventilation, water, and not disturbing a molt. Get those right and the list of things that can go wrong shortens dramatically.

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
A plump, dark abdomen with a bald patch, plus refusing food	A shrunken, wrinkled abdomen with refusing food
Lying on its back, legs up, for hours during a molt	Legs curled tightly underneath while upright
Webbing over the burrow entrance and disappearing for weeks	Sitting exposed in the open, unmoving, with a shriveled abdomen
Kicking hairs at you and leaving a bald patch on the abdomen	Any visible fluid leaking from the abdomen or a leg joint
An adult male eating almost nothing after his final molt	A juvenile refusing food 6 to 8 weeks with visible weight loss

Dehydration, the one that kills

THIS IS THE EMERGENCY, NOT THE FASTING

A shrunken, shriveled, raisin-like abdomen paired with uncoordinated legs or an inability to lift the body off the ground can be fatal within days. When a tarantula stops eating, check water access and humidity first, then look at the abdomen: shriveled means urgent, plump and dark almost certainly means premolt.

Cause, signs and response

Cause: an empty or fouled water dish, substrate that has dried out completely, or excessive ventilation in a dry room. It is the most common issue keepers run into, and it is almost always an omission rather than an accident. **Signs:** a wrinkled, shrunken abdomen, lethargy, and the death curl, where the legs pull in tightly underneath an upright body. **Response:** immediate access to a shallow water dish, and correcting the substrate moisture. Mild dehydration often resolves quickly once conditions are corrected. **Prevention:** a dish kept full and changed daily, for every species including arid ones.

THE ICU CUP, IF IT IS ALREADY ADVANCED

Keepers dealing with an advanced case often use a small container with damp paper towel or moss and a shallow water source, keeping the spider in high humidity with easy access to water while it recovers. It is a hobby technique rather than a veterinary protocol, so treat it as a last resort when no invertebrate vet is reachable, and fix the enclosure conditions in parallel.

Reading the abdomen, which is the whole skill

The abdomen is your gauge for almost everything in this package. A healthy one is plump and rounded, roughly the size of the carapace or a little larger. A dark, tight, shiny abdomen with a bald patch means a molt is coming. A wrinkled, deflated one means dehydration or a long fast that has gone too far. Learning what your particular tarantula's normal looks like, and photographing it monthly, gives you the baseline that makes the difference obvious later.

DO NOT CONFUSE A BALD PATCH WITH A PROBLEM

New World species flick urticating hairs from the abdomen when threatened, which leaves a bare, often darker patch. That is a record of past defensive behavior, not an injury or a skin condition, and the hairs come back with the next molt.

Molting, start to finish

Molting is the single most important process to understand in tarantula keeping, because most of what looks alarming in this species is a molt, and most of what actually goes wrong happens because someone interfered with one.

STAGE	WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT TO DO
Premolt	Refusing food, a darkening and plumping abdomen, a bald patch going shiny and black, reduced activity, heavy webbing	Stop offering food. Keep the water dish full. Leave it alone
The molt	The spider flips onto its back, legs in the air, often for hours	Nothing at all. Do not touch, do not flip it back, do not open the lid
Just after	Pale, soft, and visibly larger. Fangs are white rather than dark	No food, no handling, no disturbance. Water stays available
Hardening	Color returning, fangs darkening	Wait 3 to 7 days for slings and juveniles, 7 to 14 for adults, before feeding

A TARANTULA ON ITS BACK IS MOLTING, NOT DYING

This is the single most common panic in the hobby, and intervening is what turns a normal molt into a fatal one. A dying tarantula curls its legs tightly underneath itself while upright. A molting tarantula lies on its back with its legs extended. Those two postures are opposites, and telling them apart is one of the most useful things in this book.

Molting complications

Cause: insufficient humidity, or disturbance during the process. **Signs:** a molt that stalls part way, with the old exoskeleton still attached to legs or abdomen for an extended period. **Response:** a stuck molt can be fatal, and there is no reliable home fix, which is exactly why prevention carries all the weight here: proper humidity going in, and no disturbance and no feeding once it starts. **Aftermath:** a lost leg often regrows over subsequent molts, so a tarantula that comes out of a difficult molt short a limb is not necessarily in trouble.

THE MOLT ITSELF IS WORTH KEEPING

The shed exoskeleton is a near-perfect cast of the animal, and it is how keepers sex a tarantula without handling it. Log the date on page 19: molt intervals lengthen as a tarantula ages, and a record of them tells you more about your spider's stage of life than its size does.

Falls, trauma & other conditions

Falls and trauma

Cause: most falls happen during attempted handling, and the rest happen in enclosures built taller than they should be.

Signs: a ruptured abdomen, or visible hemolymph, the tarantula equivalent of blood, leaking from an injury. **Response:** a real emergency. Some keepers can stem a minor leak with a small amount of cornstarch applied to the wound, but anything beyond minor bleeding needs specialist attention if you can find it, and the outcome often depends on how fast you act.

Prevention: the low, wide enclosure on page 5 and the no-handling position on page 7, which exist for exactly this reason.

Mites and mold

Both are husbandry problems rather than illnesses. They follow poor ventilation, leftover prey, and general enclosure sanitation, and improving those resolves most cases. Remove uneaten prey within 24 hours, spot-clean boluses (the small dried pellets left after a meal), and increase cross-ventilation before reaching for anything else.

Oral nematodes

Signs: white material around the mouthparts alongside decreased appetite. **Frequency:** rare in captive-bred spiders.

Response: treatable by a vet under anesthesia where one is available, which is the practical limit. Buying captive-bred rather than wild-caught is the meaningful prevention.

Dyskinetic syndrome (DKS)

Signs: a loss of motor coordination, jerky or uncontrolled leg movement, and an inability to right itself. **Reality check:** poorly understood, often fatal, and with no well-established treatment. Some cases are associated with pesticide exposure, which is a reason to be careful about anything sprayed in the room the enclosure lives in, including household bug spray and flea treatments on other pets.

THE PATTERN ACROSS THIS WHOLE SECTION

Dehydration is prevented by a full water dish. Molt complications are prevented by humidity and being left alone. Falls are prevented by a low enclosure and not handling. Mites and mold are prevented by ventilation and removing prey. In a species with almost no veterinary safety net, that is close to the entire health plan, and all of it is free.

Setup checklist & environment targets

Essential setup checklist

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Horizontal enclosure, wider than tall, under 12 in high | ☐ About 20 × 10 × 10 in for an adult terrestrial |
| ☐ Acrylic lid with drilled ventilation holes, never mesh | ☐ Cross-ventilation on more than one face |
| ☐ 3+ in of coconut fiber, peat, or pesticide-free soil | ☐ Cork bark, half-log, or half terracotta pot as a hide |
| ☐ Shallow water dish, no drowning depth | ☐ Long feeding tongs |
| ☐ Catch cup and a piece of card, for the rare necessary move | ☐ Digital thermometer and hygrometer |
| ☐ Feeder insect supply, or a supplier lined up | ☐ Side-mounted heat mat on a thermostat, only if the room runs cold |

Environment targets

TARGET	RANGE
Temperature	70 to 80°F, room temperature in most homes
Humidity, dry-adapted species	40 to 60% commonly cited
Humidity, clinical sources	65 to 75% sometimes cited
Substrate depth	3 in minimum, half to two-thirds of the enclosure
Enclosure height	Under 12 in
Floor footprint	About 3× the leg span
Prey size	No larger than the tarantula's abdomen
Uneaten prey removed within	24 hours

Before your tarantula comes home

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Species confirmed, and its specific needs checked (terrestrial, burrowing, or arboreal) | ☐ Enclosure set up and substrate lightly moistened for a day first |
| ☐ Water dish in and full before the spider arrives | ☐ Feeder insects already sourced |
| ☐ A quiet location chosen, out of direct sun | ☐ Everyone in the house told the lid stays closed |

Emergency & quick targets

ACT NOW IF

The abdomen is shrunken and wrinkled · the legs are curled tightly underneath while upright · hemolymph is leaking from anywhere · the spider cannot lift its body off the ground · leg movement is jerky or uncoordinated · a molt has visibly stalled · white material around the mouthparts

DO NOTHING IF

It is on its back with legs extended, which is a molt · it has refused food for weeks with a plump, dark abdomen · it has sealed itself into its burrow · it has a bald patch on the abdomen · it has not moved in days. All of these are normal.

READING	TARGET
Temperature	70 to 80°F
Substrate depth	3 in minimum
Enclosure height	Under 12 in
Water dish	Full and changed daily, every species
Feeding, adult	Every 1 to 2 weeks
No feeding after a molt	3 to 7 days sling or juvenile, 7 to 14 days adult
Juvenile fast that warrants a consult	6 to 8 weeks with visible weight loss
Adult fast that is still normal	Weeks to several months in premolt

THE ONE-QUESTION TRIAGE

Is the abdomen plump or shrunken? Plump and dark with a fast means premolt: leave it alone. Shrunken and wrinkled with a fast means dehydration: fill the water dish and correct the substrate now. Nearly every scare in this hobby resolves on that single question.

Budget & shopping list

ITEM	TYPICAL COST
The tarantula, beginner species	\$25 to \$100
Chilean rose hair or curly hair specifically	\$20 to \$50; slings cost less than adults
Enclosure	\$20 to \$80
Substrate	\$10 to \$30
Hide, decor, and water dish	\$20 to \$60
Feeding tongs	Small, and worth it
Digital thermometer and hygrometer	Small one-time cost
Total initial setup, before the spider	\$70 to \$300
Feeder insects	\$5 to \$15 a month
Estimated annual total	\$60 to \$180

THERE IS NO VET BUDGET LINE HERE, AND THAT CUTS BOTH WAYS

There is no pet insurance for tarantulas and veterinary care is genuinely rare, so this is not a species where you budget for regular visits. The flip side is that when something does go wrong you may have no professional option at all, which is why the prevention items on this list are not the place to economize.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The enclosure shape and the substrate. A cheap tall enclosure with a mesh lid is the setup that produces the two most preventable deaths in the hobby, and neither is expensive to avoid. Save on decor.

THE LONGEVITY MATH

A female commonly lives 15 to 20 years or more, males typically 4 to 7. At roughly \$10 a month in feeders, a two-decade animal costs less to run than most pets cost in a single year. Buy the species you actually want.

First 90 days checklist

A longer window than the other packages, because a tarantula's first months are mostly a waiting game.

Week 1

- ☐ Leave it completely alone beyond filling the water dish
- ☐ Expect no eating. A rehomed tarantula often refuses food for a stretch, which is normal
- ☐ Confirm the room sits in the 70 to 80°F band
- ☐ Photograph the abdomen from above, as your baseline for page 11

Week 2 to 4

- ☐ Offer the first prey item, sized no larger than the abdomen. Remove it within 24 hours if untouched
- ☐ Check the substrate has not dried out completely at the surface
- ☐ Start the log on page 19: date, feeding attempt, outcome, abdomen condition
- ☐ Learn the difference between the burrow being webbed shut and the spider being absent

Month 2

- ☐ Settle into the feeding interval for the life stage from page 8
- ☐ Spot-clean boluses and any leftover exoskeletons
- ☐ Add or reposition one piece of low structure from page 20
- ☐ Watch for premolt signs: a darkening abdomen and refusal to eat

Month 3 and beyond

- ☐ When the first molt comes, do nothing, and log the date
- ☐ Keep the shed exoskeleton. It is how you sex the spider without handling it
- ☐ Photograph the abdomen monthly so a slow change is visible
- ☐ Review the log for feeding refusals that correlate with molts rather than with problems

Symptom quick reference

WHAT YOU SEE	LIKELY MEANING	ACTION
Shrunken, wrinkled abdomen	Dehydration	Fill the water dish now, fix substrate moisture (page 11)
Legs curled tightly underneath, upright	Death curl, usually dehydration	Urgent. Water access immediately (page 11)
On its back, legs extended	Molting	Nothing. Do not touch or flip it back (page 12)
Refusing food, plump dark abdomen, bald patch	Premolt	Stop offering food, keep water full (page 12)
Pale and soft, white fangs	Just molted	No food for 3 to 14 days by stage (page 12)
Old skin still attached after a molt	Stuck molt	Do not pull. Specialist help if reachable (page 12)
Fluid leaking from abdomen or joint	Rupture or trauma	Emergency. Cornstarch for a minor leak (page 13)
Jerky, uncoordinated leg movement	Possible DKS	Check for pesticide exposure in the room (page 13)
White material around the mouthparts	Oral nematodes	Vet if one is reachable. Rare (page 13)
Fuzz on leftover prey, tiny moving specks	Mold or mites	Improve ventilation, remove prey faster (page 13)
Bald patch on the abdomen	Hairs flicked defensively	Normal. Regrows at the next molt (page 11)
Rearing up, fangs displayed	Defensive, not aggressive	Back off and close the lid (page 7)

Routine & molt log

Daily

- ☐ Check the water dish is full and clean
- ☐ Glance at the spider's posture and abdomen
- ☐ Remove any uneaten prey within 24 hours

Weekly

- ☐ Feed per the life-stage interval on page 8
- ☐ Spot-clean boluses and shed skin
- ☐ Check substrate moisture at the surface

Monthly

- ☐ Photograph the abdomen from above
- ☐ Check ventilation holes are clear of webbing
- ☐ Top up substrate where it has been dug out

Occasionally

- ☐ Full substrate change, only when genuinely needed
- ☐ Re-check enclosure size against a growing spider
- ☐ Confirm no pesticides have been used in the room

Molt log

MOLT DATE	INTERVAL SINCE LAST	NOTES (LEG SPAN, SEX, COMPLICATIONS)

Feeding log

DATE	PREY OFFERED	TAKEN OR REFUSED

Enrichment checklist

Setup

- ☐ Substrate depth matched to the species, deep enough to hold a burrow shape
- ☐ A retreat the spider can web into and modify
- ☐ Water dish kept full, permanently
- ☐ Floor area beyond the minimum, without adding fall height
- ☐ Low structure to move through: cork flats, leaf litter, moss, a low branch
- ☐ Everything anchored so nothing can shift onto the animal

Monthly review

- ☐ Release live prey rather than presenting it, and vary the timing
- ☐ Let the spider keep its own rearrangements rather than tidying them away
- ☐ Add or move one piece of low structure
- ☐ Check the enclosure still suits the spider's current size

WHAT NOT TO DO

Don't read stillness as a problem. Inactivity was nearly all of the observed behavior in both conditions of the housing study, and a tarantula sitting motionless for days is just a tarantula. The trap runs the other way too: because a still spider looks the same whether the setup is right or wrong, judge the husbandry on substrate, humidity, ventilation and water, never on how busy the animal looks.

Enrichment log

DATE	CHANGE MADE	HOW IT WENT

Glossary

Sling	Spiderling: a juvenile tarantula, generally under about 2 inches.
Premolt	The weeks or months before a molt: fasting, a darkening plumping abdomen, reduced activity.
Death curl	Legs pulled tightly underneath an upright body. Usually dehydration, and urgent. Not the same as lying on the back.
Hemolymph	The tarantula equivalent of blood. It flows freely through the body cavity rather than through vessels.
Urticating hairs	Barbed abdominal hairs New World species flick defensively. Irritating to skin and genuinely dangerous to eyes.
New World / Old World	Americas versus Africa and Asia. New World species have urticating hairs; Old World species do not, and lean on bites.
Bolus	The small dried pellet of leftover exoskeleton after a meal, since digestion happens outside the body.
Sucking stomach	The muscular organ that pumps liquefied prey into the gut.
Carapace	The hard plate covering the front body section. A useful reference for judging abdomen size.
Leg span	The standard size measurement, tip to tip diagonally. Enclosure footprint is sized to about 3× it.
DKS	Dyskinetic syndrome: a poorly understood loss of motor coordination, often fatal, sometimes linked to pesticide exposure.
ICU cup	A hobby technique: a small high-humidity container used to recover a severely dehydrated tarantula.

Compiled from veterinary, university, and established keeper sources, including the controlled tarantula housing study reported in full on page 9, and cross-checked against current Beastly Facts guides at time of publication. Where sources genuinely disagree, particularly on humidity and juvenile feeding intervals, this package says so rather than choosing one. This is a husbandry reference, not a substitute for an invertebrate-experienced veterinarian where one is available, and is not a live website mirror. No external links or website CTAs appear in this document.

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